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Dave Robinson

Cornetist and music educator Dave Robinson plays a leading role in promoting the performance and visibility of traditional jazz. He directs the Capital Focus Jazz Band and was adding the finishing touches to a syllabus on trad jazz for music teachers at the time of this interview.

Dave was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are the IAJE conference in New York City and I'm pleased to have Dave Robinson with me today, cornet/trumpet player and jazz educator. Does that about cover what you do in the music business?

DR: That's the main things, yeah.

MR: Did you start out with the intention of doing one or the other, being a full time performer or an educator?

DR: Well I didn't start out with the intention of doing either one. I enjoyed playing cornet in high school and college, trumpet and cornet, and took piano lessons for a while. And actually at some point when I was young I thought I'd probably continue with piano and drop the horn but somehow it worked out the other way around. I could never get the two hands coordinated. And so I stayed with the horn through college and then wasn't sure if I would continue but I had by then a very strong interest in jazz, specifically traditional jazz. So when I got out of college a guy helped me put a band together to play traditional jazz for almost literally peanuts in a local restaurant. It was beer and snacks and a couple of bucks. But I did that for six years and that was my apprenticeship. That's how I learned to improvise, just by doing that every week.

MR: Was there music?

DR: So I wound up being a horn player and from there I went on to — I'm not a full time player, I'm what they call a weekend warrior, I play evenings and weekends. But I do a lot of gigging and have done a little bit or touring and have been very glad that I've stayed with that.

MR: Is your brother Scott older or younger than you?

DR: He's younger, Four years younger.

MR: Did you think he was crazy?

DR: Do I?

MR: I should probably tell people who don't know who I'm talking about but I was fascinated by his fascination with just the horns. And he described carrying the bass saxophone

was talking about how heavy it was, it hurt his hands but he was — damn he was going to do it.

DR: Oh he's a very determined guy.

MR: Yeah?

DR: Yeah.

MR: What was that like in your house? Did he spur your interest or was it the other way around?

DR: Well it was the other way around because I was older, so I just sort of gravitated to jazz on my own. Our parents had the usual eclectic collection of records and I kind of gravitated to the Count Basie and the ragtime piano and the Turk Murphy and Eddie Condon and that kind of thing, along with the Spike Jones, which was a big interest of mine. So I got into that and started playing it in school and, you know, not much improvising but just dabbling in it and collecting records. And Scott got interested I guess through my interest. But he soon took off and far surpassed anything I've ever done as a musician. He's an amazing guy.

MR: Yeah. He started out on a woodwind, didn't he?

DR: Yeah. An alto sax. I'm sure he told you in his interview, but he started on an alto that our grandfather gave to him that was his school horn that he still had up in the attic.

MR: Oh, right.

DR: And I have memories of Scott sitting out in the field next to our grandparent's house and tootling on the mouthpiece just to get used to making the sound with the reed and everything.

MR: That's very interesting. Going from Basie, your interest in Basie, to playing in the small group traditional jazz, did you hear a lot of traditional jazz before you tried to play it?

DR: Well yeah. I mean I heard the records that my parents had and then I started collecting as a teenager myself. So yeah I was listening a whole lot more in those days than playing. It took me 'til really after college, as I say, before I learned to improvise very well.

MR: Did you have any friends who shared your listening habits?

DR: No, not my age. I traded with some older guys, tapes in the mail and stuff.

MR: Oh I see. Your classmates were not into Turk Murphy.

DR: Actually I did have a little traditional jazz group in high school. And I formed one in college and joined another one in college so back then there was a little bit of interest. But that was really going against the grain.

MR: And then did you go on to get a music education degree?

DR: No.

MR: Your interest in both education and performance is self directed?

DR: Well yes. I got into education because, believe it or not, a gentleman in Washington, D.C., near where I live, years ago wanted to start up a youth traditional jazz band. He was a former resident of New Orleans and a friend of a lot of guys in the Preservation Hall band and so forth and he loved the music. He was a businessman and so he wanted to sponsor a youth group in town. So through the local jazz club they found me. I was starting to get into some educational things at that point in the schools, I would go out and do clinics and that kind of thing. But I wasn't directing a band until that opportunity came along. So I took that on and it's called The Capital Focus Jazz Band. It's one of the very few traditional jazz bands on the east side of the U.S. And I've been directing them for about 19 years almost.

MR: Okay I'm curious as to how much music theory you feel is appropriate or necessary for kids to know to improvise in traditional jazz.

DR: Well you certainly have to know the basics, you have to know your scales and chords. But I would say it relies — I don't know, I'm going to get in trouble no matter what I say — but I would say it relies less on, it's not so much modal playing. You know there's a lot of modal scales that people here at this conference are teaching to young people that are needed for the later styles of jazz. For these styles it's really more melody-based I think, and the changes, the chord changes tend to be simpler. But I find that that's actually a bigger challenge in a lot of cases for young players, because it is a smaller box to work within and when you have a sort of a droning flat eleven chord going on for a while you get away with a lot of different things, in fact you're expected really to step outside of that and play dissonant things and so forth. It's in some ways easier to get away with playing a solo in that kind of a setting than in a setting where you've got a set of changes, you know a 32-bar structure, a set of changes and a bridge or a multi-strain piece that changes key and so forth and you've got to stay within that and a wrong note sounds like a wrong note.

MR: I agree.

DR: It's just a whole different bag. So in my band I've had a lot of players come in highly recommended that, boy they're really hot players, but some of them, you know you ask them to play a simple 32-bar tune, like "I Got Rhythm" or something, and they're kind of all over the place.

MR: Do they have trouble remembering where they are in the song while they're trying to improvise?

DR: Sometimes. I think it's more just following the chord structure and staying within that and connecting the chords in a way that makes sense, playing a melodic line that makes sense. And for the earlier styles playing a line that makes sense stylistically and is not

using phrasing that's really outside of that genre. The young people just for the most part have not been exposed to the earlier styles.

MR: So if you're in — I'll set up a little scenario here — you have some parents talking to you about this youth band, they're thinking of having their child become a part of it, but they don't know anything about what is this traditional jazz. Can you describe it to them without playing it? What do you say to people to describe what you think traditional jazz is?

DR: Well I prefer the term traditional jazz to Dixieland, which is a name that rings a bell with a lot of people but sometimes it rings the wrong bell, which is why I like to use the term traditional.

MR: What's the wrong bell?

DR: Well we could be all day discussing that, and it's very controversial, you know some people think it's really ridiculous and highfalutin to not want to use the term Dixieland. But in my experience it has some negative baggage that I think we need to lose. So I just prefer the term traditional jazz. To some people it has a racial connotation, images of the old south and this kind of thing, to others it evokes images of striped vests and straw hats and a lot of shtick and all flash and no substance.

MR: Yeah, somebody out front with cane.

DR: And burlesquing the music.

MR: Burlesquing the music, that's a good term.

DR: And a lot of educators think — in fact my college jazz instructor, who shall remain nameless, said to me in all seriousness, he said, "Dixieland isn't jazz, it's just Dixieland." So traditional jazz — to answer your question — when I use that term and somebody doesn't know what I mean I say the New Orleans based styles. That usually does it for them.

MR: Okay if I even push this further, I guess what I am after is there a musical description that a layman can handle — well what is my son going to be doing? What kind of thing is this? He's going to be playing —

DR: He's going to be learning the early traditions of the music. He's going to be learning how to improvise within a 32-bar structure or a multi-strain tune structure that is probably unlike what he's playing against if he's improvising now in his high school jazz lab band or whatever. I just tell them that we approach it — I take the extreme view that jazz styles don't lose their relevance. Something about jazz, and I guess pop music too, we tend to throw styles away, whole genres away. We say okay that was then, this is now, so we don't want to deal with that anymore. And certainly there has to be innovation for any art form to grow. We want that, we need that, but as we add layers we shouldn't be tossing

any of the old layers. If we do that we'd better be prepared to toss out all of today's music in fifty years.

MR: I can't imagine people tossing out Coltrane. Coltrane will never be tossed out for Pete's sake.

DR: Well we say that and we hope not.

MR: Yeah.

DR: But people would have said that about Armstrong in the twenties and thirties. Armstrong is I guess kind of an exception because he had his centennial a few years back and there was a lot of attention devoted to him and you hear a lot of — people give lip service to Louis Armstrong, but you know what, they're not really out there — educators I'm talking about — they're not really out there teaching what Armstrong did or encouraging their students to try playing within that idiom. I mean it's sort of fashionable to name Louis Armstrong as sort of the top guy ever in jazz. And yet how many people think it's valid to play that way anymore? So I think it's valid to play that way. I think there's good and bad music in all the genres that jazz has come up with, all the styles. And even within traditional jazz we have styles. A lot of people don't realize that. We've got a New Orleans — we've got a couple of different New Orleans styles, we've got a San Francisco style, we've got a Chicago style, and extensions from that, and young people need to learn all this.

MR: Can you pinpoint what's the major difference between those traditional jazz styles? Is it in the rhythm section or is it in the horn ensemble playing?

DR: Well both. So for instance we have — there's various terms and there's a lot of disagreement of course, of these various styles. But my view, which sort of forms the basis of this traditional jazz curriculum kit that I've developed, is that I think most people in the traditional jazz community would agree that there's at least three sort of main branches of what we call traditional jazz or Dixieland. There's a New Orleans branch, a Chicago branch and a San Francisco branch. Most people would agree although even some musicians are really not hip to what those differences are. But basically the New Orleans sound, you've got I think two aspects of that or really three if you count the brass band sound as a style, and I do, I think that's one sound — a whole bunch of horns, no piano, no banjo, separate snare and bass drum, tuba, just a big loud raucous, joyous, kick-up-your-heels and celebrate kind of sound. Then we have the early recordings that are in the classic New Orleans style that Louis Armstrong Hot Fives, the Jelly Roll Morton Red Hot Peppers, King Oliver's Creole Jazz Band, etc. That's a very rather structured kind of style, a very tightly, kind of a tightly knit ensemble, a very rough texture but organized. And then we have the later what I call the New Orleans revival style which came to

more loose, kind of a laid back sound, a little more rough and ragged but very much from the heart. It's almost like a folk music. It tells a story. It's played right from the heart and it doesn't concern itself overly with European conventions, the classical European tradition as far as pitch and intonation and so forth. It's all about how can I tell a story. And then you have the Chicago style, which is more smooth and swingy kind of a feel, more maybe technically accomplished playing, a little bit more cerebral, and then you have the San Francisco branch which kind of harks back to the classic New Orleans style but with a twist. It's very brassy and it's very two-beat. It's kind of an um-chick um-chick instead of a bump-bump-bump-bump. Very insistent kind of swaggering rhythm. Just a very distinctive sound. Banjo and tuba instead of string bass.

MR: I was just going to ask, it's always seemed to me that whether you have a tuba or if you have a string bass really changes the music.

DR: Um hum. Although there are tuba players who can walk fours very well on tuba, and even some bands playing San Francisco style have used the string bass playing mostly on one and three. So it can be done either way. But yeah, that does generally change the character of the music.

MR: Okay. So in your curriculum, first of all what inspired you to take on this hefty project?

DR: It is hefty. What inspired me is that I just saw a gaping need and nobody else was doing it. And I felt this was something that I'm kind of maybe uniquely qualified to do because I'm a player, I'm an educator, I have full time employment in a company so I'm sort of in the corporate world so I have a little bit of savvy about fundraising and organization and so forth. And I just felt like I really had a concept of what is needed out there and by golly I just ought to go do it because it needs to be done.

MR: Is this the first IAJE you've been to?

DR: No, no. I've been to a bunch of these.

MR: Okay. So was it partly that? Going to those other conventions and seeing what was presented and what was not presented?

DR: Well it's not just from observations there at the IAJE convention. It's I mean just getting out there in the jazz world. But yeah, I guess what IAJE has been concentrating on has a lot to do with it. They are serving the needs of primarily high school and college educators whose programs tend to be built around big bands, jazz lab bands. And the idea is you need to involve as many students as possible, and the drawback is that the improvisation opportunities are limited in that kind of a setting.

MR: Well I'm glad you said that because I was wondering if — that seems an obvious thing but I was wondering if you'd thought about that, that sometimes educational settings are about numbers, so how do you address that issue of a band director who — oh yeah I

twenty kids in it, and as opposed to having a traditional group where they might have six or eight.

DR: Well I try to address that in the kit. What you can do is form two bands, or two bands where you can involve, you can double up each chair. You can either form two separate bands and keep the personnel constant, or if you need to do it in one class and involve more students, you know double up the chairs and have them take turns.

MR: Yeah.

DR: Sort of mix and match.

MR: And then maybe have them split up later, if you need to rehearse them at the same time. And it's always sometimes a time issue with people.

DR: Yeah it is. Yeah.

MR: But then you could, you know, that'd be cool you could have a battle of the bands and put them on the wagon and tie the wagon together. The kids would love that, are you kidding? They just would, I think they'd eat that up. And I just looked a little bit inside but I saw some scores, you have scores for music that — let me see if I'm stating this correctly — traditional jazz for the most part was, when the fellows originally did it, was improvised sort of on the spot, or am I incorrect?

DR: Well I mean I suppose it began largely in the brass bands as brass band players began to improvise. By the time it was recorded it was a more structured thing, that's that classic New Orleans sound that I was talking about. But probably in the earliest days, in the days of Buddy Bolden and so forth it was — actually those bands played a lot of sort of arrangements I guess.

MR: Yes they did.

DR: But to a large extent they were probably memorized and then they began to embellish them and add syncopation and so forth.

MR: So have you taken, or has someone else taken like some of the Hot Five or Hot Seven recordings and notated them into playable arrangements?

DR: That has been done. I haven't — well I've done a little bit of transcribing but not for this kit. But we do hope to include in this kit a transcription of Jelly Roll Morton's "Black Bottom Stomp." And that's something the students can play that requires no improvisation because it's what you call repertory, where you try to recreate an exact recording that's been transcribed right off the record. And that's a very challenging number. That will challenge the best young players.

MR: It'll be interesting to see if they listen to the record if they try to emulate those sounds.

DR: Well we're going to put the record on the CD in that kit.

MR: That's great.

MR: Didn't the European musicians try to emulate those sounds that they were hearing on those records and come up doing some pretty strange things to try to sound like those 78s?

DR: Well as far as traditional jazz there's actually another stylistic branch of the music that's called European trad or sometimes British trad although it wasn't confined to Britain. But they, just as the San Francisco people, Turk Murphy and Lu Watters and people like that did essentially their own twist on the classic New Orleans sound, the Europeans did their own twist on the New Orleans revival sound, that loose forties kind of thing. But they made it less loose, it was more polished, a little more structured, the drummers instead of concentrating mostly on snare there's a lot of sort of more Chicago style drum work, ride cymbal and so forth. But it's got the bass and the banjo, which is kind of the heart of this European twist. And it's called British trad or European trad. And there were some very good groups that came out of that model, the Chris Barber band, the Dutch Swing College Band, Kenny Ball, lots of very good groups.

MR: Does the word "trad" by itself have connotations that the word "traditional" does not?

DR: Well yes it does. The word "traditional," I prefer traditional jazz, as I said, to Dixieland, but one of the drawbacks of using the term traditional jazz is that that term occasionally gets applied and I would say more than occasionally gets applied to even Coltrane's music. I've seen in print the term traditional jazz as applied to hard bop as opposed to fusion or Latin jazz or free jazz. So anything that's not those is traditional in a very broad sense of the word. And yet up to the point where that word started to be used that way it was a term that was used to mean the New Orleans based jazz styles. And given all the alternatives I think it's still the best term to use. The Europeans, I don't know if they came up with it but their style they called trad, and that's the term associated with the European twist. And now trad is kind of broadened to be another name to encompass the whole breadth of the New Orleans based styles. And I use it a lot myself. And because traditional has been used more broadly I guess trad is still a term — I mean you would never hear John Coltrane, at least not yet — hear John Coltrane's music described as trad jazz. So I think, but a lot of people aren't familiar with the term trad and don't know what it means. So I don't know. Everything has its plusses and minuses terminology-wise. The road is full of bumps and potholes, you've just got to sort of pick the best. I think traditional jazz does it. I think we really should try to hang on to that term to mean the New Orleans based styles. That's what it used to mean.

MR: And does classic mean something else again?

DR: Well see classic, a lot of people use the term classic jazz to mean this. But classic jazz is a term that's even more widely and probably more properly applied to any recording or

I think you certainly can argue whether you should call John Coltrane's music traditional, but you certainly would call it classic I think.

MR: Okay. Then it becomes more of an adjective that you could apply to any field. Like classic choreography — this choreography is classic now or something like that.

DR: Um hum.

MR: Okay. And so you have a couple of partners although you're doing the —

DR: Well I'm spearheading the development of this kit. This is being done by an organization that I founded called The Traditional Jazz Educators Network, which is just exactly that, it's a network of all the teachers in the country that are showing young people how to play this kind of music. We're doing this, I'm the guy that thought up this thing and have taken on the bulk of the development part of this but with input from other members of the organization. And we're doing this in partnership with the Smithsonian Institution and IAJE and we're doing it on behalf of and in cooperation with the New Orleans Jazz National Historical Park. So part of the funding, this is being funded by the National Endowment for the Arts as well as the National Park Foundation which is an organization that does fundraising for the Park Service. Let's see and we have funding from the Rainier Foundation and from a private individual, a very substantial donation from a private individual who wishes to remain anonymous, and let's see, the American Federation of Jazz Societies has donated, the Statesmen of Jazz. I spent years getting nowhere looking for funding and then all of a sudden within the last year things have started to click so we've been able to make great progress — we've shot a lot of video master classes and that's where most of the money has to go. As you know, that's very expensive.

MR: Did Katrina put a crimp in anything, did it change or didn't you notice that?

DR: No it hasn't. It actually — I think there's more awareness now of the cultural heritage in New Orleans and what a treasure it is and what we stand to lose. And so I kind of think we're probably better positioned for funding to complete this. We want to send this out to high school and college music teachers across the country for free. We want to print these up by the thousands and drop them in their laps because that's really the only way this is going to be paid attention to.

MR: What about junior high? Have you thought about that? I'm sure you probably did.

DR: Well yes. I wanted this to really dig into the music and present — be like a textbook. I didn't want to do like a calculus textbook that just shows you how to add two plus two equals four. So I wanted it to cover the whole thing and really get deep into it so the fact that it's structured that way means it's going to be applied mostly at the college and high school level. But I did include an entry level arrangement that I did for non-improvisers.

So I think middle schools could handle pieces of this and I hope they will. And in fact I've had some middle school directors asking me for this.

MR: Well I mentioned it because my daughter teaches middle school music, and I've seen what's going on in their district near Rochester, New York. And they've got kids in junior high that are playing jazz quite well, but in the big band experience. But these kids are standing up and taking solos — I'm not sure if their solos are worked out beforehand, some of them may be. But it's quite amazing to see.

DR: Yeah, oh there's just some amazing young players out there, no doubt about it. I have the privilege of directing some of the best young players in the D.C. area in the Capital Focus Jazz Band and yeah, they constantly amaze me.

MR: What's with the bass saxophone?

DR: Everyone needs one in their living room. Oh that's just an interest of mine, a collecting interest. I'm a big record collector and have done some broadcasting, and one year, many years ago, I was searching for a topic and hit upon well it would be fun to see how many different bass saxophonists I can find in my collection. That's something unusual. And I found a bunch of them and really enjoyed doing the show and was starting to get into the sound of it, so then I just started, just like any collection starts, you pick up one or two things and then before you know it it's a disease, you can't stop. So I'm collecting bass sax recordings and I did a whole bunch of follow-on broadcasts with that and I've had fun. And that's really taken off. The interest in the bass saxophone has really taken off. I guess you can buy them on Ebay and there's new ones still being made, they're pretty expensive.

MR: Oh new horns, oh God.

DR: Yeah. I mean the major manufacturers for the most part aren't making them but there are some being made by specialty manufacturers. And boy it just seems like, I mean there's whole mailing lists on the internet devoted to bass saxophone.

MR: It just popped into my head, do you include — you know Paul Simon did that song called "You Can Call Me Al"?

DR: Right. That was Ronnie Cuber on his one and only appearance on bass sax.

MR: It's so funny when I think — and then my daughter had this video clip of when Steve Martin did the song "King Tut".

DR: "King Tut" yes.

MR: See I can't tell you anything. You are nuts.

DR: I've got it all, I'm telling you.

MR: Isn't that interesting. Who played that on "King Tut," do you know who that was?

DR: Nobody played it, it was just — it was Howard Johnson.

DR: And that was his horn at the time, I think he's sold it since then, but I don't think he actually played it.

MR: It was just, like a prop?

DR: Yeah. I sort of remember him in costume swinging it around, but I might be wrong about that. I'm almost certain that on the recorded LP version there's no bass sax. But yeah I just remember that's he's there but I'm not sure.

MR: Who was the guy that came out of the coffin playing tenor sax?

DR: Oh yeah. Oh I can't remember.

MR: I think that was Lou Marini.

DR: That sounds like it might be right.

MR: But I'm not positive. And there's our trivia for the day.

DR: Yup.

MR: And you play gigs, and you had mentioned you're playing in Washington some with one of our Hamilton College alums?

DR: Oh right yeah.

MR: Donn Andre?

DR: Yup.

MR: What band is that?

DR: They're a band called the Federal Jazz Commission. They've been playing at a little tavern in D.C. for over 25 years, every Tuesday night, and I fill in for them once in a while and I'll be filling in next Tuesday.

MR: I see. When you go to those kinds of gigs, do they have a book?

DR: You mean physically on stage?

MR: You are reading charts?

DR: No, no.

MR: Oh, okay.

DR: I think they practice tunes and routines, you know they've got a lot of things, after twenty something years, they've got a lot of things pretty well worked out, but it's all improvised. They're not reading scored arrangements by any means.

MR: Okay. Well in your curriculum is one of the goals for the students to be performing this music to be able to do it without the music eventually?

DR: That's always the end goal. I'm not — and this is just, I've tried to dig deeply into the structure of the music but, you know, teachers are only going to have so much time to devote to this. There's 23 lessons in here and each one is 30 to 40 minutes. And that's about the most I could possibly expect a teacher to — a dedicated teacher — to devote to this. So beyond that I haven't — this kit won't by itself get them to that stage. There are

to improvise. But yeah, to memorize it is a step that they're going to have to take on their own and that takes a lot of time.

MR: Is it, let's see how do I phrase this, some music educators can improvise, but many it's not part of their training. So could they actually learn along?

DR: Oh yeah. Well this is a kit for the educators. It's teach the teachers. That's what this is. Although I've tried to design this in a way that the DVD and the CD at least are things that if the teacher doesn't want to try to teach this at least maybe he or she will hand it off to some of their students as something they might want to check out. Plus I've also tried to structure this so that it can serve as an appreciation curriculum for non-musicians, just by backing out the rehearsal components and the DVD master classes, just show them, the DVD will have an opening segment that shows some of the hottest adult bands and youth bands playing this music. So if you combine that with the CD and a few other elements from the lesson plans you know you've got a good just appreciation curriculum for non-musicians too.

MR: What about things like now New York State has NYSSMA, do you know about NYSSMA?

DR: I'm not sure.

MR: It's like the New York State Music Association. It's not just jazz it's the whole gamut. And they have these big conventions every year in Rochester, New York. I'm wondering if that kind of could be a place to present —

DR: Oh you bet.

MR: Something like this, depending on how much time you have on your hands.

DR: Yeah you bet. I hope to tap into IAJE's lists for a lot of the distribution of this but yeah we do want to get it out to those who are teaching band. A lot of schools don't have a band — well a lot of schools don't have a band program but many that do don't have a jazz program although it's a whole lot more widespread than it once was. And for those who don't, this could be an entry into that.

MR: I agree and for those that might not have enough students to have the traditional big band. That's the way most people go but some schools, I know when I taught high school I had to write my own arrangements because I had an odd mix of people, I didn't have a full big band so this might be good for those kind of rural schools perhaps that don't have the numbers.

DR: Right. Well I hope so. And there are a lot of jazz lab band directors who are not players and don't improvise, maybe come from a classical background, but they still, you know, wave their arms in front of a big jazz lab band, you know, so for those who are not jazzers themselves but are willing to teach it, if they have the right tools, I hope we're

giving them the right tools here, to show their students that jazz isn't all about Charlie Parker and beyond or John Coltrane and beyond.

MR: Yeah, or David Sanborn and beyond.

DR: Yeah right. I mean the line just keeps moving forward and we can't be throwing anything away. Jazz didn't evolve, it diversified. It's not like — traditional jazz is not an embryonic predecessor to something better. It's something that came along and then others built on that and did something new and so forth. But it's not like every step has to be better than the previous one. We need all of it and it's all relevant today. We need young people to understand that.

MR: Is there some kind of racial thing with black musicians nowadays being — not playing traditional jazz? It seems like most of the bands I see are all white that do it.

DR: Well yeah, I would say so. I think outside of New Orleans this kind of music is really foreign to the culture but that goes for white and black students and Hispanics and Asian and what have you. This has just pretty much fallen off the radar screen. But yeah I mean as everybody knows a great disproportionate share of the innovations in this music have come from African-American artists. And I think the music of the African-American community is now very far removed from this kind of thing, except in New Orleans, where this kind of music is heard on the streets, even post-Katrina. It's struggling but it's still there. It's going to come back. But it's a kind of a normal part of life down there. But having said that, even down there young musicians, and I'm told from those who live there, particularly young African-American musicians, are more interested in moving forward from that taking for instance the whole neo-brass band movement, the Dirty Dozen and all the bands that they've inspired. In fact I would say probably most brass bands down there today are built more on the Dirty Dozen model than on the original sound. And what I mean by that is the Dirty Dozen took the brass band instrumentation and really completely changed the sound of it — used contemporary phrasing. The Dirty Dozen of course plays, you can hear them playing hip hop and funk and all kinds of stuff that has very little relation to traditional brass band sound at all except that it has a sousaphone in there somewhere. And that's all good too. But I think most young players, and I'm told most African-American players in that city are kind of more drawn towards that — and there's very little even there, very little participation by young people in this music. So New Orleans is particularly — New Orleans teachers — the Park in there has told me that New Orleans teachers have expressed a big interest in this. So I hope having these kinds of materials will help bring it back not only in the city where it all started but across the country.

MR: My wife and I were in New Orleans just before Katrina actually on a vacation. We heard the most amazing group of — I guess teenagers on the corner playing in a brass band. I was just —

DR: Was it sort of a funky style brass band or a traditional brass band?

MR: I think it was more traditional, although the next time we heard them, the next night, they were playing an arrangements of "Stand By Me," the Ben E. King song. But they were wailing. You could hear them for blocks.

DR: I mean it's not really the song, it's really in how it's approached, what they're doing with it. But yeah we need the brass band sound to continue to evolve, we need everything to continue to evolve. We just need to, as things evolve, we need to remain proud of what's come before and not feel like we're doing something bad by continuing to enjoy it and continuing to play it. I think young people need to be inspired to believe that they can be just as self-realized in an older style as in a newer one and that the older styles don't lose their relevance just because they first popped up many years ago. We don't do that in classical music. We don't throw out Bach and Beethoven to listen to Schoenberg. Do we? I mean you go to Carnegie Hall you'll hear Schoenberg one night and you'll hear Bach and Beethoven the next night.

MR: More Bach and Beethoven than Schoenberg.

DR: Yeah right. So why do we have to do that in jazz and popular music?

MR: It's a darn good question and I appreciate your efforts.

DR: Thank you.

MR: Well I'm glad you came by today and thanks for your time.

DR: Well I'm flattered. Thanks very much.

MR: Good luck.